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Title: Characteristics of Cybersecurity and IT Involvement by the IA Activity

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Summary:

This paper offers the inaugural large-scale, global analysis of factors influencing internal audit (IA) functions' engagement in IT and cybersecurity assurance, addressing a gap in understanding how IA adapts to digital risks. Drawing from a unique dataset of 1,142 survey responses from audit professionals worldwide, the authors examine associations between IA characteristics and their involvement in these assurance activities. Key variables include IA maturity (measured by development levels, such as structured processes and integration with governance), knowledge availability (e.g., Chief Audit Executive [CAE] holding IT certifications like CISA), and sourcing strategies (internal vs. external expertise). Regression analyses reveal positive correlations: advanced IA maturity enhances both IT and cybersecurity assurance performance, while CAE IT certification and external sourcing specifically boost cybersecurity involvement, demonstrating IA's ability to leverage outsourced expertise effectively.

The methodology relies on survey data collected through professional networks, with controls for organizational size, industry, and region to ensure robustness. Results highlight that mature IA functions are better equipped to provide value-added assurance in complex IT environments, mitigating risks like data breaches and system vulnerabilities. The study also notes limitations, such as self-reported data biases, and suggests avenues for future research, including longitudinal studies on IA's impact on organizational cybersecurity outcomes.

Practically, the findings inform standard setters (e.g., IIA), practitioners, management, and boards on strategies to elevate IA's role, such as investing in certifications and partnerships for specialized knowledge. By emphasizing IA's potential in cybersecurity governance, the paper contributes to the evolving discourse on internal controls in the digital age, underscoring the need for IA to evolve beyond traditional financial audits to address emerging technological threats.